

RESOURCE CLUSTER 3

Life in Christ

From Death in Adam to the World Made New



A Study of Salvation in the Whole Saving Work of God

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FIREPROOF STUDIES

Deep Truth. Biblical Roots. Kingdom Focus.

In This Workbook

A guided overview of God's saving work, from created life to the world made new.

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How to Use This Resource

Life in Christ is an overview of what Christians mean when they speak of salvation. It follows the Bible's great story from created life, through human rebellion and Christ's saving work, to new life, its fruit, and its final completion in resurrection.

It is not a list of steps by which a person earns his way to God. Nor is it a full explanation of every doctrine Scripture connects to salvation. It is a map: a way of seeing how the great words of the gospel belong together.

You may read it from beginning to end. That will show the argument as a whole. But you may also begin with the question nearest to you. If you are asking what happens when a person trusts Christ, begin with Chapter 4. If assurance troubles you, Chapter 6 may be the right place. If you are grieving or wondering what Christian hope finally promises, begin with Chapter 7.

This workbook is the anchor of Resource Cluster 3 (RC3), *Life in Christ*, in the Fireproof Studies library. Each chapter points outward to the cluster's fuller articles and Glossary pages. Those resources are not prerequisites. They are places to continue when one thread of the story needs closer attention.

Most importantly, keep an open Bible. This book is meant to help you see the shape of Scripture's teaching, but Scripture itself is God's Word. Scripture quotations are taken from the King James Version.

The Center of Life in Christ

Salvation is often explained as though God hands a sinner a series of unrelated gifts. First one thing happens, then another, then another. The words are biblical—faith, repentance, forgiveness, justification, adoption, sanctification, resurrection—but the picture can become misleading. A person may begin to think salvation is a conveyor belt of transactions, or worse, a system he must understand perfectly before he can rest in Christ.

The New Testament gives us a more personal center: believers are **in Christ**.

The sinner who entrusts himself to Christ in saving faith is joined to Christ by the Holy Spirit. Christ's life becomes his life. That is conversion and new birth. In that union, the believer is forgiven, brought into right standing, reconciled to God, received into God's family, given the Spirit, and granted a future no death can finally undo.

These are not competing descriptions of salvation. They are the many dimensions of one new reality.

**Salvation is God's work of uniting sinners to His risen Son through saving faith by the Holy Spirit.
Every saving blessing is found in Christ because Christ Himself is the believer's life.**

This book traces that reality through seven connected questions:

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| 1. Why do human beings need salvation? | 2. What has God done in Christ to save sinners? |
| 3. How is Christ's saving work brought before a sinner? | 4. What happens when a sinner entrusts himself to Christ? |
| 5. What becomes true of those who belong to Christ? | 6. How does Christ's life become visible in His people? |
| 7. Where is salvation taking us? | |

They are not seven stages through which every Christian consciously passes. They are seven perspectives from which Scripture describes one saving work.

PART ONE — THE NEED FOR LIFE

Chapter 1 — The Life We Lost

Why do human beings need salvation?

The gospel is not first an offer to make decent people a little better. It is God's answer to a human race that has lost the life for which it was made.

That does not mean human beings have ceased to exist, to think, to love, to build, or to show real kindness. We plainly still do all of those things. The Bible's claim is deeper: we were created to live in fellowship with God, under His good authority, and for His purposes. When humanity chose self-rule, it did not become free. It became alienated from the source of its life.

The gospel only becomes as large as it truly is when we see the size of the problem it answers.

Life Was Given for Fellowship

Life is not an independent possession which a creature owns in himself. It is the God-given reality of existence, sustained by fellowship with its Creator. Every living thing depends upon God for its existence and purpose; human life is received life.

Genesis begins there. God creates mankind in His image and likeness, blesses man and woman, and gives them a calling: “Be fruitful, and multiply, and replenish the earth, and subdue it: and have dominion” (Genesis 1:28).

Humanity was made neither to rule independently nor to watch passively while God ruled alone. Men and women were made to represent His good rule within His world. Their dominion was received, not seized. It was to be exercised under God, in fellowship with God, and for His glory.

Image and dominion belong together. In the ancient world, an image or statue could represent a king or god within his realm. Genesis uses that familiar kind of royal language in a remarkable way: God does not reserve His image for one earthly monarch. He places His living images throughout the earth. Male and female together bear His image and receive the task of filling, cultivating, and guarding the world He made.

Genesis 2 brings that calling close to the ground. Adam is formed from the dust, receives the breath of life from God, and is placed in the garden “to dress it and to keep it” (Genesis 2:15). Work, worship, wisdom, family, fruitfulness, and dominion belong together. Adam is a creature: embodied, dependent, responsible, and under God's authority. His dependence is not a defect. It is what created life is.

The Lie of Self-Rule

The serpent's temptation was not merely an invitation to break a rule. It was an invitation to determine good and evil apart from God: “ye shall be as gods, knowing good and evil” (Genesis 3:5).

Adam actively rebelled. He did not simply allow rebellion to enter the world. He rejected the rule under which his own dominion was meant to be exercised and seized dominion in himself.

Every sin has this same root. It is the creature's attempt to possess life, wisdom, and authority apart from the Creator. Sometimes it announces itself in open defiance. More often it speaks quietly: *My life belongs to me. My*

desires will determine what is good. I will decide when God may speak into my plans, relationships, body, work, possessions, and future.

But creaturely autonomy is impossible. No creature can become self-originating or self-sustaining. The attempt does not produce independent life. It produces alienation, disorder, and death.

That is why the consequences in Genesis are more than a collection of arbitrary penalties. Fellowship is broken. Shame enters human relationships. The ground resists the one appointed to cultivate it. Work becomes toilsome. Humanity is excluded from the Tree of Life. Mortal human life now moves inevitably toward dust.

Adam's rebellion did not make physical death possible; created human life was always dependent upon God. It made death inevitable, because humanity was cut off from the provision of continuing life God had given and entered a world marked by corruption, judgment, and exclusion.

We Live in Adam's World

Paul writes that “by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned” (Romans 5:12). Adam is more than a bad example. His rebellion established the human order into which we are born: a world of self-rule, fractured fellowship, frustrated dominion, corruption, mortality, and death.

To be “in Adam” is to belong by natural birth to that old humanity. We do not begin where Adam began. We enter a world already bent away from God's rule and a humanity already moving under death's reign.

Yet we are not merely victims of a damaged world. Every morally responsible person confirms Adam's claim to self-rule as his own. The forms differ. One rebellion may look reckless and another respectable; one may be public and another carefully hidden. But the governing impulse is the same: we seek life on our own terms and use God's gifts without yielding to His authority.

This is why the human problem is both inherited and personal. We receive a world and humanity shaped by Adam's rebellion; we also take up that rebellion in our own choices. The Bible will not allow us to blame Adam for everything we have done, nor will it allow us to pretend that every person begins in neutral circumstances and simply happens to repeat Adam's mistake.

This workbook does not attempt to settle every question about Adamic inheritance, moral accountability, or the death of infants. Psalm 51:5 speaks poetically of sin's pervasive depth from the beginning of life, while Romans 5 provides Scripture's clearest sustained explanation of Adam, sin, death, and humanity. The larger discussion belongs to a future study of original sin. Here we need to see the central fact: every one of us needs more than pardon for isolated failures. We need deliverance from the humanity of self-rule and death.

The Rebellion We Confirm

It is easy to treat Adam as a distant ancestor and the human condition as a problem we inherit from someone else. But the Adam–Christ contrast will not let us stay at that safe distance.

What are our sins, beneath their many forms? They are not first a list of infractions. Underneath them runs a single claim: *my life is mine*. My judgment will be the final court. My will, rather than God's Word, will decide what is right. That is Adam's voice in Eden, and it is our voice whenever we treat God's authority as advice to accept when it pleases us and set aside when it does not.

The gospel is therefore not good news merely to victims of a broken world. It is good news to rebels. We cannot put ourselves back into fellowship with God, undo our own rebellion, or raise ourselves out of death's dominion. No amount of moral effort can create the life we lack.

Left to itself, humanity has no path back to the vocation it abandoned.

That sentence is not the end of the story. It prepares us for the answer God has given.

A New Humanity Requires a New Head

God did not abandon humanity. The answer to Adam's failure is not the rejection of human life, nor merely a program for improving it. The answer is the incarnation.

The eternal Son entered the world of dust, toil, temptation, suffering, and death. He did not accept Adam's foundational lie. He lived in perfect dependence upon the Father, fulfilled the human vocation Adam abandoned, and obeyed unto death. Then He rose into incorruptible human life over which death has no power.

Jesus Christ is the last Adam: the faithful human Son and the head of a new humanity. Chapter 2 will trace His saving accomplishment more closely. For now, we need to see why His work is not merely help offered to the old humanity. Christ begins another humanity in Himself.

Natural birth places us in Adam's world. The new birth joins the believer to Christ. In Him, there is forgiveness for sin, a new standing before God, restored fellowship, a new family, and life that will finally triumph over death.

The question is not merely, *How can I improve my life?* It is, *To which humanity do I belong?*

Explore Further

- ***The World That Groans*** — a fuller biblical theology of creation, human vocation, rebellion, exile, and the hope of creation renewed.
- **The Two Adams: From Death in Adam to Life in Christ** — the fuller biblical theology behind this chapter.
- **Life** — why life is communion with God, not merely biological activity.
- **Death** — why Scripture's language of death reaches beyond the end of bodily function.
- **Image of God and Dominion** — humanity's original calling.
- **Adam, Last Adam, and New Humanity** — the two representative humanities in Scripture.

PART TWO — THE LIFE CHRIST ACCOMPLISHED

Chapter 2 — The Faithful Human Son

What has God done in Christ to save sinners?

The answer is not one event considered by itself. The cross stands at the center of God's saving work, but it is the cross of the incarnate Son—the faithful human life brought to its climactic obedience. And it is followed by His bodily resurrection, ascension, and living ministry at the Father's right hand.

The whole movement matters:

Incarnation → faithful obedience → sacrificial death → resurrection → exalted session

Jesus Christ does not merely rescue individuals from Adam's world. As the last Adam, He enters that world, fulfills the human vocation Adam abandoned, bears sin's judgment, rises beyond death's dominion, and establishes a new humanity in Himself.

The Son Entered Our Humanity

The eternal Son of God did not save humanity from a safe distance. “The Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us” (John 1:14). The One through whom all things were made took to Himself a true and complete human nature. He was born, grew, hungered, became weary, suffered, was tempted, and died.

This is the incarnation. It does not mean that God merely appeared as a man, or that the Son ceased to be God. Jesus Christ is one Person: truly God and truly human. The eternal Son possesses divine life in Himself; the human life He assumed was created, dependent, and genuinely capable of bodily death.

He entered the mortal humanity that proceeds from Adam, yet without sharing Adam's rebellion. He knew weakness and suffering, but not alienation from the Father. He faced temptation, but did not seize self-rule. His sinlessness does not make Him less human than we are. It reveals what human life under God was always meant to be.

The last Adam therefore is not an abstraction. He is the incarnate Son: the one faithful human being within Adam's world.

Where Adam Seized, Christ Received

Adam was given life, wisdom, and dominion, but treated them as though they could be possessed independently from God. Christ receives everything from the Father and lives in unbroken filial dependence.

His obedience is not confined to the last hours before the cross. It fills His whole human life: in temptation, prayer, truth, service, compassion, endurance, suffering, and mission. He says, “I do always those things that please him” (John 8:29). He does not use authority for self-exaltation, and He does not determine good apart from the Father.

This is why Christ's obedience does more than give us a beautiful example. He fulfills the vocation of humanity itself. He bears God's image without distortion. He exercises authority without autonomy. He loves, serves, works, suffers, and obeys as Adam and his descendants were meant to do.

Where Adam grasped at self-rule, Christ humbled Himself. Where Adam distrusted God's Word, Christ entrusted Himself to the Father. Where Adam's rebellion placed humanity under death's reign, Christ's faithfulness establishes the new humanity's life.

The cross is not an interruption of that obedience. It is its climax. "He became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross" (Philippians 2:8).

The Cross: Christ Gives Himself for Us

At the cross, the righteous Son gives Himself for the unjust. He does not die as a helpless victim of circumstances, nor as a merely noble martyr. He willingly offers Himself according to the saving purpose of the Father, bearing the judgment that rebellion deserves.

The New Testament uses several complementary words to explain this one work. Each answers a real question; none should be made to carry the whole weight alone.

- **Substitution:** Christ stands in the place of sinners—the Just One for the unjust.
- **Sacrifice:** He offers Himself to the Father in obedient self-giving.
- **Propitiation:** His sacrifice satisfies God's righteous wrath against sin.
- **Expiation:** the guilt and defilement of sin are put away.
- **Redemption:** those under the old dominion are reclaimed and made Christ's own.
- **Reconciliation:** hostility ends; those who were far off are brought near in peace.
- **Victory:** through His death and resurrection, the claims of sin, accusation, death, and hostile powers are decisively broken.

These are not competing theories of the cross. They are different windows through which Scripture shows us the one saving work of Christ.

Propitiation is especially important because sin is not a minor failure that a loving God simply overlooks. God is holy, and His wrath is His righteous opposition to rebellion. Yet the cross does not picture an unwilling Father persuaded to become merciful by a reluctant Son. The Father gives the Son; the Son willingly gives Himself; the Spirit sustains the offering. The cross is the united saving action of the triune God.

The Old Testament mercy seat gives a vivid picture. The broken covenant stood beneath the place where God met His people, and sacrificial blood was presented there on the Day of Atonement. Christ fulfills that pattern. He is the true mercy seat and the perfect sacrifice: **the blood that covers our broken covenant**. That covering is not concealment of an unanswered offense. In His obedient death, Christ bears judgment, removes guilt, and opens the way into God's presence.

This is why atonement is deeper than a negotiated truce. Christ does not merely arrange for God and sinners to cease hostilities. In Himself, He overcomes the division rebellion created and establishes redeemed humanity's communion with God. Reconciliation is real peace restored; atonement is the uniting work that makes that restored fellowship possible.

The purpose of the cross is therefore not merely that sinners possess a cleared record at a distance from God. It is that they may be brought to God.

The Risen Son Begins a New Humanity

If Christ had remained in the grave, there would be no new humanity and no life in Christ to share. The resurrection is not an optional proof attached to the gospel. It is the Father's answer to the obedient Son and the beginning of the future for all who belong to Him.

Jesus did not simply return to the same mortal life He had before, as though He might die again. He rose bodily into incorruptible human life over which death has no dominion. Paul calls Him "the firstfruits of them that slept" and "a quickening spirit" (1 Corinthians 15:20, 45). He is the first raised life of the new humanity.

Christ's risen human life must be carefully distinguished from His eternal divine life. The Son, with the Father and the Spirit, possesses uncreated life in Himself. His resurrected humanity is still truly human—created and dependent upon God—yet it is now deathless, transformed, and permanently beyond death's power.

That is the life believers receive through union with Him. They do not become divine, and their mortal bodies do not yet cease to die. But the life of the risen Christ has already become theirs by the Spirit, and His bodily resurrection guarantees their own.

The resurrection changes what salvation means. God is not simply returning humanity to a fragile starting point, where it might again be swallowed by death. In His risen Son, He begins a human life over which death has no power.

The Exalted Son Is Alive for His People

The risen Christ ascended bodily to the Father's presence. There He is exalted and seated at the Father's right hand. His completed sacrifice is declared sufficient; He lives as the High Priest of His people, intercedes for those who come to God through Him, and gives the promised Spirit.

This does not mean Christ is absent from His people or that His saving work is locked in the past. Salvation rests in a living Savior. The One who died for sinners is alive before the Father for them.

It is also important not to confuse Christ's present session with His future public kingdom reign. Psalm 110 gives the controlling picture: "Sit thou at my right hand, until I make thine enemies thy footstool." Christ has received all authority as the obedient, risen Son. Yet sin, death, rebellion, and suffering still visibly remain in the world. Their open subjection, the destruction of death, and Christ's promised reign await the future appointed by the Father.

Those united to Christ will share that completed dominion. The church does not seize it for itself now. It waits, witnesses, and learns the pattern of its Lord's faithful dependence. When every enemy is put beneath His feet, His people will reign with Him under the perfect rule of the last Adam.

What Christ Accomplished Is Found in Christ

The work of Christ is complete. Nothing can be added to His incarnation, obedience, sacrifice, resurrection, or exalted priesthood. But its saving blessings do not become detached objects distributed apart from Him.

Christ does not hand a sinner a portion of His obedience, a packet of forgiveness, or a future resurrection and then leave him to live independently. He joins the believer to Himself. His life, standing, peace, family, freedom, and inheritance become the believer's because the believer belongs to Him.

This is the bridge to the personal question that follows. Christ has accomplished everything needed for salvation. How does that accomplished life become the life of a particular sinner?

The answer begins when the gospel comes.

Explore Further

- **The Two Adams: From Death in Adam to Life in Christ** — Christ as the faithful last Adam and head of the new humanity.
- **Incarnation and Obedience of Christ** — why Christ's whole human life belongs to His saving work.
- **Atonement, Propitiation, Expiation, Redemption, and Reconciliation** — the complementary dimensions of Christ's self-offering.
- **Resurrection** — Christ's incorruptible human life and the believer's future bodily hope.
- **Ascension and Exaltation** — the risen Christ's present ministry at the Father's right hand and His future public reign.

PART THREE — THE SAVING ENCOUNTER

Chapter 3 — When the Gospel Comes

How is Christ's saving work brought before a sinner?

Christ's saving work was accomplished in history before any of us heard of it. His incarnation, obedience, death, resurrection, and exaltation do not wait for our response to become true. But the Christ who has accomplished salvation must be made known. A sinner cannot entrust himself to a Savior he has never heard.

That is why the gospel is central. It is God's authoritative good news concerning His Son: Christ died for our sins, was buried, rose again, and saves all who trust in Him. It is the announcement of what God has done, not advice about what man must achieve.

The gospel is also more than a formula for getting benefits from Christ. It brings the crucified and risen Christ before the hearer as Savior and Lord. It announces that God has acted, and therefore summons every hearer to repent, believe, and entrust himself to the Son.

The Word That Announces Christ

Paul summarizes the heart of the apostolic message: "Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; and that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures" (1 Corinthians 15:3–4). These are public events, not private religious feelings. Christ really died. He was truly buried. He rose bodily. He was seen alive by witnesses (1 Corinthians 15:5–8).

The good news is therefore news. It tells the sinner what God has already done in His Son.

But biblical good news is never mere information placed on a table for detached inspection. The herald announces the King's victory, deliverance, and coming peace. When Jesus preached, He said, "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel" (Mark 1:15). The announcement carries a summons because the One announced is the rightful Lord.

The order matters. God has acted in Christ; therefore the sinner is called to turn from self-rule and trust Him. Repentance and faith do not complete Christ's work or turn grace into human achievement. They are the necessary reception of the Christ whom the gospel reveals.

God Draws People Toward the Light

No one comes to Christ by an autonomous discovery. The Father must draw. Jesus says, "No man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him" (John 6:44).

Drawing is God's gracious action by which He brings a person toward the light He has given and, through the gospel, toward the crucified and risen Son. It does not perform faith for the hearer, coerce his will, or give regenerating life before faith. It is God's prior and necessary movement toward people who would not otherwise come to Christ.

That drawing may begin before a person hears the gospel plainly. Creation bears witness to the Creator. Conscience testifies that human beings are accountable to more than their own desires. Providence may unsettle

a life built on self-rule, create a hunger for truth, bring a person into contact with Scripture, or place a gospel messenger in his path.

The Ethiopian eunuch illustrates this. Before Philip reaches him, he has traveled to worship and is reading Isaiah. He is seeking truth but does not yet understand the Christ to whom Isaiah points. God directs Philip to him, and Philip “preached unto him Jesus” (Acts 8:35). The eunuch’s seeking did not save him or make the gospel unnecessary. It was part of God’s drawing movement toward the message he needed to hear.

Cornelius gives the same pattern. He fears God, prays, and responds to the light available to him. Yet the angel tells him to send for Peter, who will speak words “whereby thou and all thy house shall be saved” (Acts 11:14). His prior devotion is not regeneration. It is not a substitute for Christ. God is bringing a seeker to the gospel.

Missionaries continue to report this kind of providential preparation. One [SEND International account] (<https://www.send.org/deportation-to-appointment>) from Eurasia tells of a student who had become dissatisfied with his religion and prayed, “God, if you are real, send me someone to tell me about you.” At the same time, a missionary was being unexpectedly moved from another field into the student’s city. They met, studied Scripture over several months, and the student finally surrendered his life to Christ. The account is an illustration, not a doctrinal proof; but it is a contemporary reminder that God still brings seekers and gospel witnesses together.

We should be careful here. Scripture does not promise that every person who begins to seek will receive an identical extraordinary intervention. Yet it does teach that no morally accountable person is left without God’s witness. Romans 1 describes a humanity that knows enough of God through creation to be responsible, and Acts 17 says God orders times and places “that they should seek the Lord.” The decisive question is not whether God has given light, but what we do with the light He gives.

The Spirit Applies the Gospel

When the gospel comes, the Holy Spirit works through that Word. His work is neither a vague religious atmosphere nor a replacement for the message of Christ. The Spirit brings the proclaimed gospel home to a particular person.

Three related actions need to be distinguished.

Drawing brings a person toward truth and, in the gospel, explicitly toward Christ. It concerns direction: God graciously moves toward the sinner and calls him toward the Son.

Enlightenment gives real understanding of the gospel. What once sounded like a distant religious story becomes intelligible, weighty, and true. A person may come to see that Jesus is who the gospel says He is, that His death and resurrection matter, and that he himself stands in need of mercy.

Conviction is the Spirit’s application of that understood gospel to the human will. Conviction exposes not only particular sins but the self-rule beneath them. It says, in effect, *This Christ is true. This sin is yours. This life cannot remain your own.* Without the gospel there may be sorrow, regret, fear, or a wounded conscience. But there is no distinctly Christian conviction apart from the Spirit applying the gospel of Christ to the will.

These actions are real grace. They make the saving encounter possible. Yet none of them should be confused with conversion or regeneration. A person may be drawn, understand the gospel, feel its moral force, and still refuse the One it reveals.

Light Can Be Resisted

The Bible does not describe unbelief as innocent neutrality. Romans 1 says that people suppress the truth they have received. Jesus says, “men loved darkness rather than light, because their deeds were evil” (John 3:19). Stephen tells his hearers, “Ye do always resist the Holy Ghost” (Acts 7:51).

Resistance takes different forms. It may be open hostility, intellectual evasion, endless delay, fear of what surrender would cost, attraction to Christ's benefits without submission to His authority, or the quiet insistence that one will remain the final ruler of his own life. In every form, the issue is more than lack of evidence. Evidence cannot perform repentance or faith on behalf of a will that insists upon preserving self-rule.

Repeated resistance can become hardening. What begins as refusal can form a settled habit of interpreting truth as a threat. Scripture also speaks of God judicially giving people over to a path they have persistently chosen. That does not mean God creates innocent unbelief. It means that He judges chosen resistance by confirming its dreadful direction.

This warning should not be used carelessly. A person may resist grace and later repent. Doubt, delay, seasons of rebellion, and even serious failure are not themselves proof that someone has passed beyond repentance. The church's work remains to proclaim Christ, pray, warn, and invite living people to come to Him.

The Word May Be Received Without Taking Root

Jesus' parable of the sower is especially important because it prevents us from treating every response as either obvious hypocrisy or complete conversion. Some receive the Word with joy. Luke says that they “for a while believe” (Luke 8:13). The Word springs up, yet there is no root. Under temptation or pressure, the response withers. In another soil, the Word is choked by cares, riches, and pleasures, and brings no fruit to maturity.

This is **temporary belief**: a real but unrooted reception of the gospel. The person may understand it, assent to it, feel its power, rejoice in it, identify with Christian people, and change in visible ways. Yet he has not finally surrendered himself to Christ in saving faith. The Word has not become his rooted life in Christ.

This does not mean the initial response was necessarily insincere. It means that awareness, agreement, emotion, and even public religious activity are not the same as giving oneself to the Lord. Enlightenment can say, *I see that this is true*. Saving faith says, *Because this is true, I give myself to Christ*.

The difference is not that one person heard a living Word and the other heard a dead one. Nor is it that one began to respond and the other did nothing at all. The difference is between a response that remains unrooted and a response in which Christ's life becomes the person's own.

That is why warnings matter. They call us away from borrowed religious experience and toward Christ Himself. But the warnings are not meant to make a trusting believer examine his own roots endlessly in terror. Rooted life rests ultimately in the life of the Savior, not the intensity of the branch.

The Question the Gospel Places Before Us

The gospel brings every hearer to the same decisive issue. Christ has been revealed. His saving work has been announced. The Spirit has borne witness, drawn, enlightened, and convicted. Will the hearer retain his claim to self-rule, or will he entrust himself to the Son?

The gospel does not ask a sinner to manufacture life, improve himself enough to deserve mercy, or recite magic words. It calls him to come to Christ.

The next chapter considers that response closely: faith, repentance, surrender, conversion, regeneration, and union with Christ. These words describe different sides of the one saving encounter in which the sinner believes and the Spirit gives life.

Explore Further

- **How to Be Saved** — a clear presentation of the gospel and its summons to personal trust in Christ.
- **What Does It Mean to Be Saved?** — New Testament salvation language, one passage at a time.
- **Gospel** — the good news concerning Christ and His accomplished work.
- **Drawing, Conviction, and Enlightenment** — the Spirit's preparatory work and its distinct actions.
- **Resistance and Hardening** and **Temporary Belief** — the danger of refusing or receiving the Word without rooted surrender.

Chapter 4 — Receiving the Life of Christ

What happens when a sinner entrusts himself to Christ?

The gospel brings a real summons. Christ has been made known; the Spirit has applied the truth to the heart and will. What response does God call for?

Scripture answers with several words: believe, repent, receive, come, call upon, confess, follow, yield, and abide. These are not rival methods of salvation. They are different ways of describing one decisive turning from self-rule to Jesus Christ.

At that turning, the Holy Spirit gives the sinner new life by joining him to the risen Son.

When the sinner entrusts himself to Christ in saving faith, the Spirit joins him to Christ so that Christ's life becomes his life. This is conversion and regeneration, and in this union every saving blessing becomes his at once.

This is the center of salvation. It is not merely a better record, a religious feeling, a prayer repeated, or an improved version of the old life. It is a new existence in Christ.

Faith Is Trusting Surrender

Faith is trusting reliance upon God as He has revealed Himself in Jesus Christ. It includes believing what God has said, but it is more than agreement that the gospel is true.

A person may understand the gospel, affirm its facts, and even experience its emotional force while still holding himself back from Christ. Saving faith says more than, *I see that this is true*. It says, *Because this is true, I give myself to Christ*.

Faith is therefore a choice of the will. It is not an involuntary religious feeling, a spiritual substance implanted into a passive person, or the intensity of one's inward certainty. The Father draws. The Spirit enlightens and convicts. The gospel reveals the crucified and risen Son. None of these gracious actions removes the sinner's own response. He may continue to resist, or he may entrust himself to Christ.

This choice does not make faith a work that earns salvation. The light, truth, opportunity, drawing, conviction, and ability to respond are all grace. Faith receives what Christ has accomplished; it does not add to it. Yet it remains genuinely the person's faith. No one can believe in another person's place.

To trust Christ means trusting the Person the gospel reveals, not merely seeking the benefits He gives. A sinner may want relief from guilt, fear, loneliness, or the consequences of sin while still retaining final authority over his own life. But Christ is not received in pieces. He is Savior and Lord.

Repentance Is Faith Turning from Self-Rule

Repentance and faith are not two separate conditions arranged in sequence. They are one turning viewed from two directions.

- **Repentance** is turning from sin, falsehood, self-rule, and every former allegiance.
- **Faith** is turning to Christ in trusting reliance.

Surrender makes the personal reality plain. To surrender is to give oneself to Jesus Christ and give up the supposed right to rule oneself. It is not an additional work after faith and repentance. It is what both words are saying.

The sinner does not offer Christ a polished life in exchange for salvation. He comes as a rebel who cannot repair his own condition. He turns from self-rule because he is entrusting the whole self—guilt, future, fears, desires, and hope—to the Lord who alone can give life.

This does not require complete understanding or finished obedience before one may come to Christ. A new believer has much to learn and a lifetime in which Christ's life will take visible form. But saving faith does change the fundamental allegiance of the self. The question is no longer, *May I remain my own master?* It is, *What does my Lord command?*

For this reason, the gospel invitation should not be reduced to a prescribed sinner's prayer. A prayer may be the honest expression of a person who is coming to Christ, and many have rightly called upon Him in prayer. But no set of words can do the surrender in another person's heart. The invitation is to address God truthfully for oneself: to confess need, turn from self-rule, and entrust oneself to the crucified and risen Lord.

Conversion: One Decisive Passage

Conversion names the decisive passage from self-ruled life in Adam into surrendered life in Christ. It is the transition from the old humanity to the new.

The language of conversion protects us from two errors. On one side, salvation is not merely a private human decision detached from God's action. The gospel comes from God; the Spirit draws, enlightens, and convicts; Christ alone has accomplished salvation. On the other side, conversion is not an involuntary divine event that makes the sinner believe after the fact. The sinner truly turns and entrusts himself to Christ.

The clearest way to hold both truths together is simple:

The sinner believes; the Spirit gives life.

Faith does not regenerate. Trust cannot manufacture resurrection life, as though believing intensely enough could create a new heart. And the Spirit does not do the believing in the sinner's place. He gives life to the person who has entrusted himself to Christ.

In conversion, these distinct actions meet. The sinner's faith is real and personal; the Spirit's act is wholly divine and life-giving. Neither should be confused with the other, and neither should be separated into two independent saving states.

Regeneration: The Spirit Gives New Life

Regeneration, or the new birth, is the new life the Holy Spirit gives when a sinner trusts Christ. It is not moral renovation of Adam's old life. It is the Spirit joining the believer to the risen Christ so that Christ's life becomes his life.

Jesus tells Nicodemus, "Ye must be born again" (John 3:7). Birth is an especially fitting biblical image because it names a genuinely new origin, identity, family, inheritance, and future. The person remains himself; God does not erase him and replace him with another. But he now belongs to a new humanity and lives from a new source.

The new birth should not be made to cancel the Bible's other language. John can speak of receiving Christ and believing on His name, then say that those who do so become the children of God (John 1:12–13). Jesus can speak of coming to Him, believing on Him, and abiding in Him. Paul can speak of dying and rising with Christ, of becoming a new creation, and of being made alive together with Him. These are not contradictory accounts. They show the same saving reality from different sides.

The conception of a child provides a limited but useful analogy. At conception, many distinguishable realities begin together: a new identity, family relationships, a future, and a life of its own. Those things can be distinguished without imagining that each arrives as a separate event. In the same way, conversion brings a new existence into being. The biblical metaphor remains new birth; the analogy simply helps us see why Scripture's many descriptions of salvation need not be divided into a spiritual assembly line.

Union with Christ: His Life Becomes Ours

Union with Christ is the living relationship formed when the Spirit joins a believing sinner to Jesus Christ. It is the goal toward which every saving blessing moves.

Jesus gives the controlling picture in John 15: "I am the vine, ye are the branches." A branch does not merely receive legal recognition from the vine, imitate its outward appearance, or carry away a supply of life to use independently. It lives from the vine. "Without me ye can do nothing" (John 15:5).

That is what it means to be in Christ. Christ remains the believer's life. The believer does not become divine, acquire life in himself, or lose his own personhood. He remains a redeemed human being, continually dependent upon the risen Son. Yet the union is real: Christ abides in His people, and they abide in Him.

This is why salvation cannot be reduced to benefits detached from Christ. Forgiveness removes the guilt that obstructed fellowship. Justification brings the believer into right standing in the righteous Son. Reconciliation

restores peace with God. Adoption gives the believer a place in God's family. Redemption releases him from the old dominion and claims him for Christ. The Spirit indwells him. These are not independent gifts distributed one by one. They are the many dimensions of sharing the life of Christ.

Chapter 5 will explore those blessings more fully. Here the central point is that they all belong to the believer because he belongs to Christ.

A New Creation Has Begun

“If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature” (2 Corinthians 5:17). New creation begins in the resurrection of Jesus Christ and is entered through union with Him.

The old identity in Adam has passed away. The believer has a new origin, life, allegiance, relationship, vocation, and destiny in Christ. He has not merely been returned to Adam's original condition. Christ rose into a kind of human life over which death has no dominion, and the believer now shares that risen life through the Spirit.

This new creation is already real and irreversible. It will become increasingly visible through sanctification and reach its full bodily expression in resurrection. The believer's mortal body may still weaken and die, but death cannot finally sever him from the life of the risen Christ.

The Word that came in the gospel has now become rooted life. This is not yet sinless or completed life. It is life that will grow, bear fruit, and endure because its root is Christ Himself.

Explore Further

- **What Is New Life?** — the full explanation of faith, repentance, conversion, regeneration, and union with Christ.
- **How to Be Saved** — a concise, front-facing gospel resource for a seeker or the Christian sharing Christ with a friend.
- **Faith, Repentance, Surrender, and Receiving Christ** — four complementary ways Scripture describes the saving turn.
- **Conversion, Regeneration / New Birth, and Union with Christ** — the decisive passage, the Spirit's life-giving act, and the relationship established.
- **New Creation and Eternal Life** — the new existence already begun in the risen Son.

PART FOUR — THE LIFE WE RECEIVE IN CHRIST

Chapter 5 — Every Blessing in Christ

What becomes true of those who belong to Christ?

When a sinner is joined to Christ, God does not give him one benefit with more perhaps to follow. He gives him everything that belongs to life in His Son. Paul blesses “the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ” (Ephesians 1:3).

The final phrase is the key: **in Christ**.

The blessings of salvation are not stored separately, as though God distributes them one parcel at a time. They are held in a Person. When the Spirit joins the believer to Christ, the believer shares the life, standing, relationship, family, belonging, Spirit, and future that are found in Him.

Every saving blessing is a dimension of sharing the life of Christ.

We may distinguish these blessings because Scripture does. But we must not divide them into a chain of independent transactions. The same saving union that gives new life also brings the believer into right standing, restores peace, grants a place in God's family, frees him from the old dominion, and secures his inheritance.

A New Standing: Justification, Forgiveness, and Redemption

The sinner's problem is not simply that his record contains bad deeds. He is out of line with the holy God who made him. His guilt is real, but so is his dislocation. He has lived under self-rule and cannot set himself right.

God answers this condition in Christ. He forgives: sins are not ignored but removed as the debt and offense that stood against the sinner. He redeems: through the costly blood of Christ, the sinner is released from the old dominion and claimed as Christ's own. Redemption does not appraise a prior worth equal to the cross; it shows what Christ chose to make His people by making them His treasured possession.

At the center of this new standing is **justification**. Justification is God's righteous act of bringing the sinner into right standing by placing him in the standing of Christ Himself. “Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ” (Romans 5:1).

The courtroom language is true. God really declares the believing sinner righteous, and Christ's righteousness is truly credited to him. But the declaration is not a legal fiction floating free of reality, nor is the courtroom the whole picture. God can truthfully declare the believer righteous because He has truly placed him in Christ's righteous standing.

To be justified is to be brought into line. The believer's standing does not rise and fall with his performance because it was never built on his performance. It is established in the Righteous One.

The verdict is true because God has brought the believer into the standing of Christ.

A Restored Relationship: Reconciliation, Peace, and Access

An acquittal can leave a person free without making him a friend. The gospel does more. It ends the war between the sinner and God and brings him near.

This is **reconciliation**. Those who were enemies are reconciled to God by the death of His Son (Romans 5:10). Atonement is Christ's deeper uniting work; reconciliation is the restored peace and relationship that work establishes. The believer is not merely tolerated under a truce. He is restored to the fellowship for which human life was made.

That reconciliation gives **peace with God**. This is an objective reality: hostility has ended, the believer has been brought into right relationship with his Creator, and the peace rests on Christ's finished work rather than on a passing emotional state.

It also opens the way for **peace from God**: the settled rest God gives His children as they live within the right relationship and purpose He restores through Christ. This peace may be felt more strongly at some times than others, but it grows from the objective peace Christ has already made.

With reconciliation comes **access**. "Through him we both have access by one Spirit unto the Father" (Ephesians 2:18). The way into God's presence, once barred, now stands open. The believer approaches not as a defendant nervously returning to court, but as one Christ has brought near.

A New Family and People: Adoption, Acceptance, and Citizenship

God is not only the Judge who justifies. In Christ, He is the Father who receives.

Adoption is God's act of granting those in Christ the recognized standing, inheritance, and full rights of sons within His household. The believer is not merely pardoned and sent away; he is taken into the family, given a name, a place, and a future. Pardon says, *you may go free*. Adoption says, *you may come home*.

New birth and adoption are not rivals. New birth names the life and origin the Spirit gives. Adoption names the recognized family standing, inheritance, and welcome the Father grants to those in His Son. Both are true of the believer in the same saving union.

The believer is also **accepted in the beloved** (Ephesians 1:6). He is not accepted on probation or because he has managed to improve himself. He is accepted in Christ, the Beloved Son. His acceptance rests where His justification rests: in the Son, not in the fluctuating quality of his own obedience.

And the new family is never a private arrangement. Those in Christ become "fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the household of God" (Ephesians 2:19). Their citizenship is in heaven; their first belonging is now to Christ and His people. This does not erase earthly responsibilities, Israel's future, or the diversity of redeemed nations. It gives every lesser belonging its proper order under the Lord.

Salvation therefore creates a people. The church is not a collection of strangers who happen to receive similar benefits. It is the household and visible fellowship of people who share one life in Christ.

The Spirit's Presence: Indwelling and Seal

God does not give these blessings at a distance. He gives His own Spirit to dwell in those He has joined to Christ.

The Spirit who gives life in conversion remains with the believer. He makes the believer a dwelling place of God, forming personal communion with Christ and joining every believer to the one body of His people. Christian life is never meant to be self-managed independence; it is life in the Spirit of the Son.

The Spirit is also a **seal** and an **earnest**. He marks the believer as God's own and serves as God's pledge of what remains to come. "After that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise, which is the earnest of our inheritance" (Ephesians 1:13–14).

An earnest is the first portion that guarantees the rest. The Spirit given now is not merely an inward encouragement. He is God's own pledge that the life begun in Christ will reach its promised completion.

The Spirit within the believer is God's down payment on everything He has promised.

The baptism of the Holy Spirit and the Spirit's indwelling must not be collapsed into one question. Christ's outpouring of the Spirit constituted His New Covenant church; indwelling is the Spirit's personal presence in those joined to Christ. Both belong to the saving purpose of God, but they answer different questions.

A Secure Inheritance

Children are heirs. Those in Christ are heirs of God and joint-heirs with Christ (Romans 8:17). Their inheritance includes resurrection life, a place in God's renewed creation, and a share in the blessings that belong to the Son.

The inheritance is already secured, but not yet fully possessed. The believer has the Spirit as its pledge; he does not yet see the renewal of his body, the liberation of creation, or the public reign of Christ. He waits as a genuine heir whose future is certain.

Christ is presently seated at the Father's right hand, awaiting the final subjection of His enemies. His promised public reign is still future, and those united to Him will reign with Him when it comes. The believer does not await an independent throne or an autonomous life. He awaits the full sharing of Christ's life, creation, and reign as a beloved creature of God.

This is not anxious hoping. It is settled waiting: kept for the inheritance, and the inheritance kept for him.

One Christ, Every Blessing

Step back and see the whole gift. A new standing before God. A restored relationship. A place in the Father's family. A belonging among God's people. The Spirit's personal presence. A future that cannot fade.

These are not six separate gifts. They are one gift, seen from several sides. The believer is justified, reconciled, adopted, accepted, made a citizen, indwelt, and made an heir because he is in Christ.

Every blessing has one address: in Christ.

The poorest believer, newly come to Christ, already possesses every saving blessing because he already possesses Christ. The most mature believer has not moved beyond that foundation. He is still learning to know more deeply the Son in whom everything is already his.

This gift is never an excuse for passivity. The life Christ gives takes root and becomes visible. The next chapter considers how Christ's life bears fruit in those who belong to Him—and how that fruit strengthens assurance without becoming the price of salvation.

Explore Further

- **In Christ: Every Blessing** — the fuller article on the blessings of salvation as one shared life.
- **Justification** — the believer's right standing in the righteous Son.
- **Forgiveness, Redemption, Reconciliation, and Access to God** — the saving work that removes the barriers between sinners and God.
- **Adoption, Acceptance, and Citizenship** — the believer's family and corporate belonging.
- **Indwelling, Seal of the Spirit, and Inheritance** — God's present presence and secure future pledge.

PART FIVE — THE LIFE THAT TAKES ROOT

Chapter 6 — Rooted Life Bearing Fruit

How does Christ's life become visible in His people?

Every saving blessing is already the believer's in Christ. Nothing remains to be earned or purchased. Yet a life that is given is meant to be lived. Christ does not give His people an inert possession to set aside; He gives them His own life.

Living things grow.

Jesus gives the governing image: “I am the vine, ye are the branches: he that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit” (John 15:5). A branch does not manufacture fruit by sheer effort. The life of the vine flows into it, and fruit grows as the result.

So the first thing to say about the Christian life is not a demand but a promise: what God plants, He grows. The growth is not always quick, even, or easily measured. But the life of Christ does not remain invisible forever.

Root and Fruit

Everything depends on keeping one distinction clear.

The **root** is the new life itself: union with Christ, the risen Son's life given to the believer. The **fruit** is what that life produces: love, holiness, obedience, good works, service, endurance, and a gradually changed character.

Fruit grows from the root. It does not create the root, and it does not buy it.

Paul says that salvation is “by grace ... through faith ... not of works,” and then immediately adds that believers are “created in Christ Jesus unto good works” (Ephesians 2:8–10). The order cannot be reversed. We are not saved by good works; we are saved unto them.

This protects the gospel from an anxious attempt to earn what Christ has already freely given. Yet it also protects grace from being misunderstood as barren. A truly living branch bears. A profession that never produces any fruit over time offers no reason to think that the Word has become rooted life in Christ.

Fruit grows from the life. It never buys it.

Sanctification: Set Apart and Made Like Christ

The Bible's word for this growing life is **sanctification**. It has two inseparable aspects.

First, when the sinner is joined to Christ, God sets him apart as His own. He belongs to God and is given a new purpose. Second, throughout the Christian life, the Spirit increasingly forms the character and life of Christ in him.

Sanctification is therefore neither a second salvation nor a self-improvement project. The old life in Adam cannot polish itself into the new creation. The Spirit works from within the believer, changing desires, habits, thinking, relationships, and actions as Christ's life takes visible form.

This work is real, but it is not sinless perfection in the present life. Growth may be uneven. Christians still struggle, repent, learn, and sometimes fall grievously. The question is not whether a believer has reached an impossible flawlessness. It is whether the life of Christ is actually becoming the direction and power of his life.

The believer genuinely participates. Scripture commands him to walk in the Spirit, put sin to death, put on the new man, love, forgive, serve, and obey. But these commands are never a call to establish a righteousness apart from Christ. They are the response of a branch to the life already supplied by the vine.

The fruit is the fruit **of the Spirit**: love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, and temperance (Galatians 5:22–23). It includes actual good works, but it is more than religious activity. Christ's life becomes visible in a changed heart and in real love, faithfulness, obedience, worship, generosity, and service.

Abiding Is Continuing Reliance

The saving faith by which a sinner comes to Christ does not become irrelevant after conversion. It becomes the continuing reliance by which he abides in Christ.

Abiding is not the believer recreating his union with Christ every morning. A branch does not generate the vine's life, and a Christian does not keep himself alive by spiritual strain. Abiding is continuing dependence, trust, receptivity, obedience, and communion with the Savior who has already given life.

It is therefore the opposite of self-rule. The believer learns to bring his fears, temptations, work, relationships, suffering, and hopes under the care and authority of Christ. He does not outgrow dependence; he grows into it.

This is why sanctification is both active and restful. The believer strives against sin, but not as one trying to earn admission into the vine. He obeys because Christ is his Lord and life. He rests because the life he is learning to live comes from Christ, not from himself.

Kept by God

The Christian's endurance is real. Those who belong to Christ continue in faith and bear fruit. But their perseverance rests finally on God's keeping, not on their own spiritual tenacity.

Peter says believers “are kept by the power of God through faith unto salvation” (1 Peter 1:5). Paul is confident that He who began a good work will perform it until the day of Jesus Christ (Philippians 1:6). Jesus says of His sheep, “I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish” (John 10:28).

Divine keeping is not distant observation. The Father, Son, and Spirit actively preserve those who belong to Christ. God keeps His people through His Word, the Spirit, prayer, the church, correction, trial, encouragement, and warning. He keeps them through continuing faith—not as though faith competes with grace, but as the trusting reliance His preserving work sustains.

The believer is not held by the strength of his grip. He is held by Christ.

This is the proper ground of assurance. A believer does not belong to Christ because he feels strong on a particular day. He belongs to Christ because the risen Son has given him life, the Father has received him, and the Spirit has sealed him as God's own.

The Warnings Are Real

Scripture nevertheless gives severe warnings. Jesus describes those who receive the Word with joy, “for a while believe,” and then fall away because they have no root (Luke 8:13). Hebrews warns against an evil heart of unbelief that departs from the living God. These warnings are not empty threats or imaginary situations.

They do not, however, teach that a person who has received Christ's rooted, regenerating life later becomes the old creature again. Final apostasy reveals that the Word, however near and powerfully experienced, never became rooted life in Christ. It is not ordinary failure, doubt, fear, or a season of disobedience. It is the knowing and settled repudiation of Christ after profound exposure to the gospel.

The warnings and God's keeping are not enemies. The warnings are among the means by which God keeps His people. They expose self-rule, awaken the sleepy, summon the wandering to repentance, and teach true believers to abide in Christ.

The church must therefore speak with both seriousness and tenderness. It should not dismiss a professing faith with no fruit. Neither should it diagnose every weak, wounded, or struggling Christian as an apostate. Peter denied Christ and was restored. A living person who grieves over sin, desires Christ, or turns to Him in repentance should be directed to the gospel, not told that he has passed beyond mercy.

Assurance: Look First to Christ

How can a person know that this life is truly his?

Assurance begins outside the believer: in Christ's finished work, God's promise, and the Spirit's witness. “The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God” (Romans 8:16). The primary ground of confidence is not the strength of one's emotions or the abundance of one's visible achievements. It is Christ.

The believer should not stare endlessly at himself, taking his spiritual pulse hour by hour to see whether his faith is strong enough. That turns assurance into a new form of self-reliance. He should look first to Christ—His cross, His promise, His life, and His keeping.

Scripture also gives a real, secondary confirmation. John writes “that ye may know that ye have eternal life” (1 John 5:13), and points to faith in Christ, love for the brethren, obedience, and walking in the light. These are not payments that purchase assurance. They are the marks that rooted life leaves.

The order matters:

Look mostly to Christ. Then look for His life in you.

Fruit keeps presumption honest. A claimed faith with no root or fruit is a claim worth questioning. But Christ keeps the anxious believer from despair. Small fruit, ongoing struggle, and a need for continual repentance do not overturn the promise of the One who grows and keeps what He has planted.

Kept for What Is Ahead

Rooted life does not end in private moral improvement. The life Christ gives is moving toward an inheritance: resurrection, glorification, the sight of God, the renewed creation, and the shared reign of the people of Christ under their King.

The believer is already secure and not yet home. He abides, grows, heeds the warnings, and lives in hope because the One who gave life is the One who keeps it. The final chapter turns to that promised completion.

Explore Further

- **Rooted Life and Assurance** — the fuller pastoral study of fruit, divine keeping, warnings, and assurance.
- **Sanctification, Holiness, Obedience, and Good Works** — Christ's life taking form in the believer.
- **Fruit** — the visible expression of rooted life in Christ.
- **Assurance, Perseverance, and Divine Keeping** — why a believer's confidence rests in Christ's preserving work.
- **Temporary Belief and Apostasy and Falling Away** — the difference between unrooted reception and final repudiation.

PART SIX — THE LIFE THAT WILL BE COMPLETE**Chapter 7 — When Life Is Complete****Where is salvation taking us?**

God keeps the life He gives, but He keeps it for something. Salvation is not a possession to clutch in place. It is a present reality with a promised completion.

The Christian hope is not that a forgiven soul will drift forever in a shadowy, bodiless heaven. God has promised resurrection from death and a creation made new, where His people will live before Him forever.

This is not a lesser hope than life with God after death. It is fuller. God saves the whole person. The body matters. Creation matters. Human vocation matters. The risen Christ is the beginning and guarantee of the future God will bring.

Salvation is going somewhere.

The Hope Is Resurrection

The center of Christian hope is bodily resurrection. Christ did not merely survive death. He rose bodily into incorruptible human life over which death has no dominion. He is “the firstfruits of them that slept” (1 Corinthians 15:20): the first of a harvest that guarantees the rest.

The resurrection of believers is therefore not an afterthought. If Christ had not been raised, Paul says, Christian preaching and faith would be empty and sinners would remain in their sins (1 Corinthians 15:14–17). But Christ is risen. His resurrection reveals what salvation will finally become in all who belong to Him.

Human beings were made for embodied life under God. The rebellion brought that life under death's dominion; salvation must answer the ruin all the way to the body. “For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality” (1 Corinthians 15:53).

The resurrection body will be truly ours, yet transformed—no longer weak, corruptible, or subject to death. Glorification is God's final work of making believers fully like the risen Jesus Christ. It completes the new life already given in Christ when their bodies are raised beyond death's power.

The hope is not out of the body, but out of death.

When a Believer Dies

Until Christ returns, believers still die. Death remains grievous. It separates families, breaks the wholeness of embodied life, and rightly brings sorrow. Jesus Himself wept at a grave. Christians do not need to pretend that death is good.

Yet death cannot sever a believer from Christ. To die is to be with Him. Paul speaks of departing “and to be with Christ; which is far better” (Philippians 1:23), and of being absent from the body and present with the Lord (2 Corinthians 5:8).

The believer who dies is not lost, unconscious in nothingness, or returned to Adam's dominion. His mortal body has died, but Christ's life remains his life. He is with the Lord who has kept him.

Still, this blessed presence with Christ is not the final completion of salvation. Human beings were made for embodied life. Paul looks beyond being “unclothed” to being “clothed upon,” “that mortality might be swallowed up of life” (2 Corinthians 5:4). The believer with Christ awaits the resurrection of the body along with all God's people.

To die is to be with Christ. To rise is the hope beyond even that.

When Christ Appears

The full completion arrives when Jesus Christ appears. The Lord Himself will descend; the dead in Christ will rise; those who are alive at His coming will be changed; and His people will forever be with Him (1 Thessalonians 4:16–17; 1 Corinthians 15:51–52).

The return of Christ opens questions about the order and ages still to come—questions that deserve careful study in their own place. But RC3 holds one boundary clearly. Christ is presently seated at the Father's right hand, awaiting the future subjection of His enemies. His public kingdom reign and the church's co-reign with Him are future realities, not a completed condition of the present age.

When He appears, the victory already secured in His resurrection will be openly displayed. Every hostile power will be brought beneath His feet, and death, the last enemy, will be destroyed (1 Corinthians 15:26).

The people of Christ will not receive independent rule or become autonomous. They will share the restored dominion of the last Adam under His perfect authority. What Adam seized in rebellion, Christ receives in faithfulness; what Christ receives, He graciously shares with His redeemed people.

Judgment Will Set Things Right

The future also includes judgment. God will expose what is false, judge unrepentant rebellion, vindicate what is right, and remove sin and death from His creation. This is not divine irritation. It is God's holy setting-right of all things through His Son.

For those in Christ, judgment is not a trial whose verdict remains uncertain. Jesus says that the one who hears His Word and believes has everlasting life and “shall not come into condemnation; but is passed from death unto life” (John 5:24). “There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

The believer's guilt has been answered in Christ. His judgment in that judicial sense is settled. He will not be returned to condemnation or to the old humanity.

Yet the believer's life remains meaningful and accountable. Christ will evaluate the faithfulness expressed through the life He gave: the use of opportunity, service, stewardship, love, and obedience. He will reward what

is worthy and expose what is empty. This is not a second salvation trial; it is the righteous evaluation of a child by the Savior who has already secured his place in the family.

For the believer, judgment is not a trial. It is a vindication.

Judgment is therefore hope as well as warning. God will not overlook evil, abandon the wounded, or allow injustice to have the final word. The Judge is the risen Christ who gave Himself to bring sinners to God.

A Creation Made New

The end of salvation is not an abstract eternity. It is the new heavens and new earth: the renewed creation God will bring when He completes His saving work.

John sees “a new heaven and a new earth,” and hears the great declaration: “Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them” (Revelation 21:1–3). God wipes away tears. Death, sorrow, crying, and pain are gone. The curse is removed. The Tree of Life, once barred to Adam's race, stands within the city where the river of life flows from the throne of God and of the Lamb.

The deepest blessing is not merely the absence of pain, although that promise is precious. It is the presence of God. His people see His face. They live in the open fellowship for which humanity was created, now made secure forever in the risen Son.

The end answers the beginning. Humanity was created for embodied life, communion with God, dependent dominion, and a fruitful place within His good world. Through rebellion, that vocation was disordered and brought under death. In Christ, it is restored and carried forward into a creation that cannot again be lost.

The redeemed are not returned to a fragile Eden. They are brought into a renewed creation secured by the last Adam who has passed through death and will never fall.

The story ends in a garden—and surpasses it.

Life Complete

Now the whole story can be seen at once.

Humanity was created for life under God, but in Adam chose self-rule and entered death. The faithful Son entered that humanity, fulfilled its vocation, died for its rebellion, and rose into deathless human life. Through the gospel, the Spirit brings sinners to Christ; when they entrust themselves to Him, He joins them to the risen Son and gives new life.

In Christ, believers are brought into right standing, peace, family, freedom, the Spirit's presence, and a sure inheritance. That life takes root, bears fruit, and is kept by God. At the last, Christ raises and glorifies His people, vindicates them before all creation, and brings them into the world made new.

That is salvation, whole and complete: not merely a corrected record, but a new life; not merely a collection of benefits, but union with a Person; not merely relief from death, but resurrection life in the Son.

From death in Adam to life in a world made new: this is what God has done.

If you belong to Christ, this is where you are going. And if you have not yet come to Him, the invitation still stands. The gospel does not offer you an abstract future. It offers the risen Son Himself, and in Him life that death can never finally take away.

Explore Further

- **When Life Is Complete** — the fuller article on resurrection, judgment, and the renewed creation.
- **Resurrection, Glorification, and Death of the Believer** — Christ's life through death and into bodily completion.
- **Judgment** — no condemnation in Christ and meaningful evaluation of the believer's faithfulness.
- **New Heavens and New Earth, New Jerusalem, and Hope** — the future God has secured for His people.
- ***The World That Groans*** — creation, rebellion, curse, and the hope of creation renewed.

Continue the Study

This workbook gives the whole shape of salvation. The rest of **Life in Christ** lets you follow any part of that shape more closely. You do not need to begin in the same place every time. Begin with the question before you, then follow the connections Scripture supplies.

Five Core Articles

- **The Two Adams: From Death in Adam to Life in Christ** — Why Adam and Christ stand at the center of the Bible's account of humanity, rebellion, and restoration.
- **What Is New Life?** — What kind of life the Spirit gives when a sinner is joined to the risen Christ.
- **In Christ: Every Blessing** — Why forgiveness, justification, adoption, peace, and inheritance are not separate transactions, but dimensions of life in Christ.
- **Rooted Life and Assurance** — How Christ's life takes root, bears fruit, and gives real assurance without making salvation depend on performance.
- **When Life Is Complete** — Resurrection, judgment, the future reign of Christ, and the creation made new.

Begin With Your Question

If you are asking...	Begin with...
What is wrong with humanity?	Life, Death, Adam, Original Sin, In Adam
Why did Jesus have to become human and die?	Incarnation, Obedience of Christ, Atonement, Propitiation, Redemption
What must I do to be saved?	Gospel, Faith, Repentance, Surrender, Conversion
What does it mean to be born again?	Regeneration, New Birth, Union with Christ, Eternal Life
What changes when I belong to Christ?	Justification, Forgiveness, Reconciliation, Adoption, Peace with God
Can I know that I belong to Christ?	Assurance, Divine Keeping, Perseverance, Rooted Life and Assurance
What is ahead for the believer?	Resurrection, Glorification, Hope, New Heavens and New Earth

The doctrine pages define these terms. The articles explain them. The teaching resources help churches and families work through them together. All of them point to the same center: **Christ Himself is the believer's life.**

Key Terms at a Glance

Adoption — God's granting to those in Christ the recognized standing, inheritance, and full rights of sons within His household.

Atonement — Christ's reconciling and uniting work that brings sinners to God.

Conversion — the decisive turning from self-rule to Christ in saving faith and repentance.

Faith — chosen, personal trust in Christ: entrusting oneself to Him rather than relying on oneself.

Forgiveness — God's removal of sins as the barrier between the sinner and Himself through Christ.

Glorification — God's final work of making believers fully like the risen Christ when their bodies are raised beyond death's power.

Gospel — the good news of what God has done in His Son and the summons to come to Him.

Grace — God's freely given goodness, shown most fully in His saving work in Christ and reflected in the kindness His people show others.

Justification — God's righteous act of bringing the sinner into right standing by placing him in Christ, whose standing is perfectly right before the Father.

New Birth / Regeneration — the Spirit's gift of new life when the sinner is joined to Christ through saving faith.

Peace with God — the restored relationship with God made possible through Christ.

Propitiation — Christ's sacrifice satisfying God's righteous wrath against sin.

Reconciliation — God's ending of the hostility between Himself and sinners through the death of His Son, bringing those far off near in peace.

Redemption — Christ's costly release of sinners from the old dominion, claiming them as His treasured possession.

Repentance — faith turning away from self-rule and surrendering to Christ's authority.

Resurrection — God's raising of the body into life beyond death's power, patterned after the risen Christ.

Salvation — God's rescuing work by which He brings sinners into the life of His Son.

Sanctification — God's setting apart of His people for Himself and His ongoing formation of them into Christ's likeness.

Union with Christ — the Spirit's joining of the believer to the risen Son, so that His life becomes the believer's life and every saving blessing is found in Him.

Scripture Index

The following passages form the principal biblical framework of this workbook. They are offered as starting places for continued reading, not as isolated proofs detached from their contexts.

Passage	Primary connection in this workbook
Genesis 1:26–28	Humanity created in God's image for dependent dominion
Genesis 2:16–17; 3:22–24	Life, rebellion, death, and the Tree of Life
John 3:1–8	The necessity of the new birth
John 5:24	Passing from death to life; no condemnation in Christ
John 15:1–11	Abiding in Christ and rooted life that bears fruit
Romans 5:12–21	Adam, Christ, death, and the new humanity
Romans 6:1–11	United with Christ in His death and resurrection
Romans 8:1–39	No condemnation, the Spirit, adoption, and final glory
1 Corinthians 15	Christ's resurrection, bodily resurrection, and death defeated
2 Corinthians 5:14–21	New creation and reconciliation through Christ
Galatians 2:20	Christ's life in the believer
Ephesians 1:3–14	Every spiritual blessing in Christ and the Spirit's seal
Ephesians 2:1–10	From death to life by grace through faith
Philippians 1:21–23	The believer's death and presence with Christ
Colossians 1:13–23	Redemption, reconciliation, and Christ's supremacy
Colossians 3:1–4	The believer's life hidden with Christ and future appearing
Titus 3:3–7	Mercy, regeneration, renewal, and grace
1 Peter 1:3–9	New birth, living hope, inheritance, and divine keeping
Revelation 21–22	The new creation, God's presence, and the Tree of Life

A Final Word

The Christian life begins, continues, and ends in Christ. Do not look first to your performance, feelings, or ability to hold yourself together. Look to the risen Son. He is the life God gives, the life God keeps, and the life God will one day complete.